

SESSION SEVEN: THE TURNING AWAY

The Qilvayas Symphony

An adventure for 4–6 characters of 6th level — the price of the Seal, the rooms beneath the rooms, and the faces that would not look

OVERVIEW

The party opens the Second Seal and descends into the Undercourt's deepest reach: three chambers of a sacred site built for a ceremony that two people were supposed to walk out of. This is not a dungeon crawl. It is an approach, and each chamber strips something away rather than throwing something at them — the practical wreckage of preparation, a corridor that makes them honest, and finally the Witness Hall, where several hundred people watched the empire's founding and chose to see nothing. The session ends on the frieze and what it means, with the party holding proof that could end houses.

Designed for a five-hour core. Pacing budget: the price of the Seal (45 minutes); the Vesting Room and Nyreeza's camp (60 minutes); the Long Approach and the memory pressure (60 minutes); the Witness Hall (90 minutes, including the Turned); the frieze and the implications (45 minutes). Optional content adds roughly 90 minutes. Combat is deliberately sparse — one encounter, and it is a puzzle wearing a fight's clothes. Milestone: the party reaches 7th level at the session's close.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

The founding was witnessed. Several hundred people stood in the Witness Hall to see Zhuvedus and Threnvos swear the covenant that would make an empire — and when Zhuvedus broke it, the assembly turned away in unison. In this world's metaphysics that is not cowardice; it is mechanism. Oaths bind because they are witnessed (Tarnovari stone-oaths, marriage before a Church witness, Norr's landholders swearing before the assembled hall). When the assembly refused to see, they unwitnessed the covenant — and the unbinding is what made the betrayal possible rather than merely unpunished. Zhuvedus struck the blow. The witnesses made it a founding.

Two consequences run the rest of the campaign. First: the shadow does not feed only on broken oaths, it feeds on the silence around them — every institutional look-away in the empire is the same act as the Hall, which is why the Brekelands' ghoulish density tracks unburied parley-breaches and not banditry. Second: witnessing starves it, and the Vigil — watched, lit, never left alone — is the counter-rite. The Vigil is penance. It was instituted by the witnesses or their children as an apology none of their descendants remember making, and it is the one practice that survives unchanged across every schism in the empire. The party already performed it correctly at Redwatch, for men they killed, for no reward, and nobody told them.

Third, and the piece that reframes the throne: the Golden Tablets were composed by the witnesses. The empire's sacred founding law is the self-exoneration document of the

people who looked away — which is precisely what Nyreeza meant by “the wound predates the Wall. The Tablets were written over it.” The law was the cover-up, written first. Qilvayas is rewriting the Tablets right now, and a legal code that makes oaths enforceable, witnessed, and recorded is, in this metaphysics, a literal starvation regimen against the thing beneath his city. He built the only real weapon by institutional instinct, without any idea what he was doing. His Daily Draw — the one habit his clerks find inefficient — is him personally witnessing one citizen a day. It is the most important thing he does.

The scouring is a second crime and the same crime. Roughly two hundred years ago, as the fracture began, Emperor Vaskaren the Restorer went looking for why his empire was failing, found the Witness Hall, and had it methodically erased by masons working for weeks — an act of un-witnessing performed by the one family the founding had made. His restoration failed. Qilvayas is the second restorer of that line and does not know whether he is repeating the pattern or breaking it. Vaskaren's order survives in the dynastic archive; it is how Empress Nyreeza found the way down, and it is what waits, unopened, in her sealed dispatch case.

SCENE 1: THE PRICE OF THE SEAL

The Seal has not changed since you left it. Twenty feet of black stone furred white in air that has never known winter, the carvings in an alphabet your educations do not contain, and at its foot the word a dead Empress scratched when her cipher stopped being enough. The cold is a pressure now, not a temperature. And behind the stone, slower than you remember it, something breathes.

The Seal is not a puzzle and not a check. It is a door built to be opened from the ceremonial side by two people speaking together — and there is one party, on the wrong side, two thousand years late. What opens it is an oath: a real one, spoken aloud by a player character in the place where sworn words carry, and meant. Not a password, not a formula. An actual commitment the campaign will hold them to.

Running it: Tell the players plainly that the door responds to sworn words. Do not tell them what to say. Let the table sit in the silence; it will be uncomfortable, and it should be. Whatever a character finally says, write it down verbatim. That promise is now load-bearing and the thing below heard it.

Weight, not wording: Any sincere oath opens the Seal. A joke, a hedge, or a deliberately trivial vow does nothing at all — the stone simply does not respond, and the failure is not a mechanic to be gamed but a mirror. A character who tries to

cheat the door and then swears honestly gets in on the honest attempt.

What it costs: The oath is real. Record it in the Branch Ledger. The campaign should honor it — keeping it earns nothing mechanical, but breaking it, later, in front of the thing that heard it, is the single worst thing anyone in this party can do.

When the oath is spoken, the Seal does not grind or shudder. The frost sublimates off its face in one breath, the carvings run with condensation like a fever breaking, and it opens inward on a stair, and the smell comes up.

SCENE 2: THE VESTING ROOM

You expected the grave. What you get is cedar smoke and resin — faint, cold, two thousand years stale, and unmistakably the smell of a rite: the incense of an oath-swearing, the scent of every formal room any of you have ever stood in. Your noses say temple. Your noses say celebration. Everything else says otherwise. The chamber is small and practical: stone benches, a dry basin, iron pegs along one wall. Preparation happened here. Two sets of everything — and one set is still laid out, folded, on the bench where it was left.

The room where the two of them prepared, and the room where the party understands what kind of place this is. The unused ceremonial vestments are the module's quietest artifact: someone folded them, set them out, and nobody ever put them on. They are undecayed — the cold has kept them — and they are the correct size for a Drow of ordinary build.

NYREEZA'S CAMP

In the corner, three years old and immediately recognizable: a bedroll, the ash of a small fire, a stub of surveyor's chalk, and a stack of notes weighted under a stone. She camped here. For some length of time — the notes suggest a week, perhaps more — an Empress of Zhuvendus sat alone in this room and worked. Give this discovery room to land; the party has been following her for six sessions and this is the first place she stayed.

The notes (readable, her cipher, and the party has the key): Measurements. Sketches of the paired architecture with the second figure's absence marked and re-marked. A list of nine names in the old orthography, seven crossed out. And one page that is not survey work at all: a draft of a letter to her son, begun four times and abandoned four times, the longest attempt reaching eleven words. "Qilvayas — there is a thing under our house that we" and then nothing.

The archive citation: One marginal note references a dynastic archive shelf-mark, not a public one. If the party pursues it later, it leads to Vaskaren's scouring order — and to the fact that Nyreeza read it before she came down. She knew what she was looking for.

What is not here: A body. No blood, no struggle, no remains. She left this room walking. (Her fate remains open by design — do not resolve it here or anywhere else without deciding to.)

SCENE 3: THE LONG APPROACH

The corridor beyond is built for a crowd: forty feet wide, colonnaded, a processional way meant to carry two columns of witnesses walking in together. Your footsteps do not echo. Words go flat and short, swallowed within a pace or two, and you find yourselves standing closer than you meant to. The cold sharpens. It is not the cold of winter or of stone. Every one of you knows this cold from somewhere else: the corridor outside a sickroom, the moment before bad news, the specific chill of a place where something has just been lost. Your hands stay warm. Your chest aches.

Two systems govern this corridor, and neither is a trap in the mechanical sense.

SWORN WORDS CARRY

Ordinary speech dies within a few feet. Sworn language does not. An oath, a vow, a promise — even a casual "I swear" — rings down the full length of the corridor with perfect clarity and keeps ringing a half-second longer than it should. The party will discover this by accident, almost certainly from someone saying something they did not mean formally. Do not explain it. Let them work it out, and let them start watching their language. A table that begins self-censoring their characters' speech out of superstition has arrived exactly where this dungeon wants them.

THE MEMORY PRESSURE

The corridor does not attack. It makes people honest. As the party advances, each character surfaces an unkept promise of their own — not a vision, not an illusion, not a save: plain intrusive memory, the specific and personal kind that arrives unbidden at three in the morning. Ask each player, once, quietly, in whatever order feels right: "What does your character remember that they'd rather not?"

Handling the answers: Whatever they say becomes canon. Record it. This is the single most valuable thing the module produces — six sessions of established characters, and now the DM holds each one's worst unfinished business, volunteered by the player. It will feed personal arcs for the rest of the campaign.

If a player declines: Let them. "Your character keeps it down" is a legitimate answer and a characterful one. Do not push; the corridor is patient and so is the campaign.

Shadows: Somewhere along the corridor, an observant character (passive Perception 15, or anyone who thinks to check) notices that shadows fall toward the deep places rather than away from the light. Let the player who spots it be the one to say it aloud.

SCENE 4: THE WITNESS HALL

The corridor opens and the ceiling goes away. A hall the size of a cathedral, tiered on all four sides — stone benches rising in ranks, hundreds upon hundreds of places, each one worn in the particular way stone

wears when someone has stood on it a long time. This room held an audience. At the center, below the tiers, a floor of pale inlaid stone waits for a ceremony. And every surface that once bore a face or a name has been scoured smooth — not smashed, not defaced in rage: ground down, methodically, by people who took their time and were paid for the work.

The Hall is the session's destination and the campaign's hinge. Run the discovery in three movements, and do not rush any of them.

FIRST MOVEMENT — THE SCALE OF IT

Let the party simply understand the room. A DC 14 Intelligence (Investigation) or any Seal-house education establishes the seating capacity at several hundred; the wear patterns establish they stood rather than sat, and stood for a long time. Whatever happened here was public, formal, and attended. The empire's official account of the founding — a hero, a wilderness, a divine mandate — contains no mention of an audience at all.

SECOND MOVEMENT — THE TURNED

When the party moves onto the ceremonial floor, they wake. See the stat block. The Turned are what remains of witnesses who died having never looked back — faceless, not by mutilation but by absence, their heads permanently averted from whatever they are nearest to. They do not approach. They do not attack anyone who is looking at them. They move, and strike, only when unobserved.

The encounter is a puzzle wearing a fight's clothes. Killing them is possible and unsatisfying and the room gets colder for it. The solution is to look at them — specifically, for a character to hold their gaze on one and not stop, and say what they see. A Turned that is witnessed — truly attended to, named aloud as a person who was here and did nothing — stops. It turns. It has no face to show, but it turns, and then it is gone, and the cold in that part of the room eases. This is the party's first practical proof that witnessing is the counter-rite, and they will not have been told.

Scaling: Four characters: 4 Turned. Five: 5. Six: 6, and one of them is a Turned Elder (as Turned, but 68 hp and its Unobserved Strike deals an extra 1d8). If the party solves the witnessing trick early, do not punish the discovery by adding more — let them clear the room fast and feel clever. The scene's payload is the frieze, not the fight.

THIRD MOVEMENT — THE FRIEZE

The scouring is thorough. It is thorough on the floor, on the plinths, on every tier your lantern reaches — and then, on the highest tier of the eastern gallery, forty feet up where the light barely goes and a man on a scaffold worked alone at the end of a long day, it stops. Two spans of frieze survive. Faces. Dozens of them, carved with the particularity of portraiture — this nose, this jaw, this braid, this house-sigil worked into a collar. They are not fleeing. They are not screaming. Every single face is turned away, deliberately, in the same instant, with the composure of people who have decided together and without a word to see nothing at all.

Give the table the silence. Then let them work out what they are looking at, and do not help them. The pieces are all present: an audience, a founding, a betrayal, and several hundred people who chose not to witness it. If nobody

arrives at it, that is fine — the rubbing goes in their pack and the realization can land in Session Eight, or at Vaelindra's table, or three sessions later at the worst possible moment.

The rubbing: Taking one is the obvious move and the party has the technique (Session Three). It is the only record of the founding's true shape above ground, and the faces are identifiable — house-sigils, distinctive features, enough that a Crownlands noble could recognize an ancestor. Several of those houses currently hold seats at Qilvayas's court.

The trap the Hall sets: The party now holds proof that delegitimizes the throne mid-restoration, hands Orlath a weapon, vindicates Tarnovar, and probably breaks the Church. Keeping it quiet is safer for everyone — and keeping it quiet makes them the newest witnesses to turn away. The room has just finished teaching them what that costs. Do not state this. They will feel it, and the ones who do not will feel it later.

Evidence of the scourers: DC 15 Investigation on the floor beneath the surviving frieze: two centuries of dust, and under it, a rust-stain the shape of a scaffold foot, and a single broken mason's chisel of imperial make. Someone was paid to do this. The order has a name on it, and the name is in an archive the party can eventually reach.

End the session in the Hall, under the faces. The way onward — a low arch on the western side, unscoured because nothing there bore a name — is visible, and the breathing comes from it, and it is slower than it was. Milestone: 7th level.

OPTIONAL CONTENT (BEYOND THE FIVE-HOUR CORE)

The Ninth Name (~40 minutes, in the Vesting Room): Nyreeza's list of nine names in old orthography, seven crossed out, is a genuine puzzle: they are the nine great houses that stood in the front rank of the Hall. Seven are extinct. Two are not. A party that works this out — Vell can help, so can a good History check against the surviving frieze sigils — learns which two families at court descend directly from the front row, and the DM gains a pair of NPCs with two thousand years of buried motive. (Which houses is the DM's call; choosing an existing court figure is recommended and delicious.)

The Chisel's Maker (~30 minutes): The broken chisel bears a maker's stamp — a masons' guild mark still in use in Aenodira, because the guild is dwarven and dwarven guilds do not change their marks. The current guildmaster can date it within a decade and will, if approached respectfully, consult the guild's own work-ledgers: two centuries back, a large commission, paid from the imperial purse, its purpose left blank. Dwarven record-keeping outlasts imperial cover-ups, and the guild has never once been asked about it.

What the Vestments Fit (~20 minutes): A character who thinks to compare the unused ceremonial vestments against themselves learns they are cut for a Drow of ordinary build. In an empire where the Founder's Blood is nearly extinct and the dynasty is its last house, that is a fact with a very short list of implications — and the party may reach the correct one two sessions before anyone tells them the second champion's name.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

Record outcomes in the Branch Ledger.

The Seal-oath, and who swore it: The character who opened the door is now personally bound in the campaign's central mechanism, and the thing below heard them. Note the exact words. If that character is ever pressured to break that specific promise — and the campaign should eventually arrange it — that is a session-defining crisis, not a moral quandary.

The memory pressure answers: Each character's volunteered unkept promise is now canon and is the seed of their personal arc. Players who declined keep the ambiguity; do not force it later, but the corridor remembers, and so does the DM.

The Turned — witnessed vs. destroyed: Witnessed: the party has practiced the counter-rite without being taught it, and Session Eight's Vigil will come to them intuitively. Destroyed: the Vigil is harder, the room is colder, and the DM should let the party notice — in Session Eight — that the ones they killed are still here, still turned, still waiting to be seen.

The rubbing, taken or left: Taken: the party carries a political bomb, and every faction that learns of it wants it. Left: the Hall stays a secret they merely know, which is safer and quietly corrosive — and the DM should note who argued for leaving it.

Told or untold: Whether the party ever shows the rubbing to Shen, Vaelindra, Vell, Orlath, Tarnovar, or the throne is the campaign's largest live decision from here forward. Every recipient is a different second half. Flag it prominently and do not rush them.

STAT BLOCKS

The Turned
Medium undead, neutral
Armor Class: 14 (grave-formal dress, hardened)
Hit Points: 52 (8d8 + 16)
Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	14 (+2)	15 (+2)	8 (-1)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Damage Resistances: necrotic, cold; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks
Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, prone
Senses: blindsight 60 ft. (it has no eyes and does not need them), passive Perception 11
Languages: understands Old Imperial; cannot speak
Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

Averted. The Turned has no face. Its head is permanently averted from whatever it is nearest to, and it cannot be made to look by force, damage, or magic — only by being witnessed.

Only When Unobserved. The Turned can move and attack only while no creature is looking directly at it. A creature that spends its action watching one Turned (declared openly) freezes that Turned entirely for the duration. This is the encounter's core tension: attention costs actions, and there are more of them than there are of you.

Witnessed. If a creature holds its attention on a single Turned for one full round AND describes aloud what it sees — naming the Turned as a person who stood here and did nothing — the Turned turns to face the speaker, is laid to rest, and vanishes. No check. No damage. This is the intended solution and the module's whole thesis.

The Colder Room. Each Turned destroyed by damage rather than witnessed lowers the temperature of the Hall by a degree the party can feel, and the DM should say so, every time, without explanation.

ACTIONS

Unobserved Strike. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target that cannot currently see it. Hit: 14 (3d6 + 4) necrotic damage. The Turned cannot make this attack against a creature that is looking at it.

Turned Elder (six-character parties): as the Turned, but 68 hit points, and its Unobserved Strike deals an extra 4 (1d8) necrotic damage. It is the one at the front.

LOOT AND FOUND REWARDS — SESSION SEVEN

Find	Value / Effect
The unused ceremonial vestments	Undecayed, cold-preserved, cut for a Drow of ordinary build. Not magical. Worth more than anything the party owns.
Nyreeza's working notes	Her measurements, the nine names, the four abandoned letters to her son, and a dynastic archive shelf-mark that leads to Vaskaren's order.
The frieze rubbing	The only above-ground record of the founding's true shape. Identifiable faces and house-sigils. A political weapon and a moral test.
The broken mason's chisel	Imperial make, guild-stamped, two centuries old. The physical thread to the scouring order.
Nyreeza's surveyor's chalk (second stub)	Mundane. Half-used. Free. Put it next to the first

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"They are not fleeing. They are not screaming. They have decided, together and without a word, to see nothing at all."